

The giant leap: Earlier this year, Dhruv Jurel, Rajasthan Royals wicketkeeper-batter, earned his maiden call-up to the India side.

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concentration but also allows the bowling team to find breakthroughs. So, when we are on the pitch, we make it a point to constantly talk from the back and bother the batters. That trick seemed to have worked against England.

Wicketkeeping is not an easy job, especially catching edges and making quick stumpings. Did you focus on specific areas to prepare for this challenge in Test cricket?

It's all about practice. Things get a bit difficult in red-ball cricket because you need to judge a swinging delivery. In Tests, after 80 overs, you take a new ball, so it's another challenge to adapt to it.

While batting during the Test series, I even faced new balls, so you need to be ready for those situations.

Since I am a middle-order batter, I hardly get to face the new ball in the white-ball format, so I can still train with old balls. But you can't afford to do that in red-ball cricket. In Tests, you need to face new balls or be ready to face reverse swing. So, one needs to practise hard. Adaptability is the key. You need to have a clear-cut vision and approach things differently for red-ball and white-ball cricket.

How do you handle the pressure?

A year ago, I would feel the pressure or be nervous ahead of a big game. But ever since I have played for Rajasthan Royals and the Indian team, I don't feel any

pressure. If you do a reality check, you will find that no cricketer could maintain an upward graph forever in his career. Just like success, failures are also part of the game, and they come suddenly.

I also know that if I don't lead a disciplined life, take things easy, or become a bit lackadaisical in my training regime, there is a possibility of downfall. Hence, it is important to keep working hard because that's in your control and not crib about the uncontrollables.

You said that those few weeks with the Indian team were a learning experience. What did you learn?

I got a chance to rub shoulders with some of the legends of the game and pick their brains. It was also a reality check for me. Ultimately, it's about sustainability. A lot of players have featured for India, but not everyone could hang in there, so I need to ensure that I don't get carried away. I genuinely believe that *jo bhi milestones banaya hai, woh toh insaan hi banaya hai* (milestones are set by human beings after all), so if they can do it, why can't I? And, who knows, I can do even better than them. Everyone has their own story; it's about how you write it.

With Rishabh Pant and K. L. Rahul back in the mix, the competition has gone up for the wicketkeeper-batter's slot. Do you enjoy this healthy competition?

I am a big fan of Kobe Bryant and the Mamba mentality, so whenever I am a bit low, I listen to his old podcasts and draw inspiration. I don't see it as a competition because, at the end of the day, everyone is playing for India and

winning matches. That's what matters.

I keep asking myself whether I am moving forward and taking my game to the next level, as I believe that we compete with ourselves and not with anyone else.

With the game evolving, has the role of a wicketkeeper-batter become more difficult, especially in white-ball cricket?

Every wicketkeeper-batter has his designated batting position, and people often criticise players without understanding their job. Batting at No. 7 or No. 8 is always difficult. I had a conversation with (MS) Dhoni *bhaiya* regarding this, and he told me that "if you bat at No. 7 or No. 8, failures are certain. You need to cut out the noise and not think about what people say. If you manage to win two out of 10 games for your team, that's enough..."

Those words inspired me a lot. When you bat down the order in a high-pressure situation, you don't know what the bowlers are thinking, and you can't afford to waste time. People often consider wicketkeepers as additional batters, but it's not always easy to bat in tricky situations.

(Smiles) The competition will be there, but you just need to focus on your game and move on.

Soon after the Test series against England got over, Rohit Sharma took to social media to post a picture with Sarfaraz, Yashasvi Jaiswal and Shubman Gill. What has been the impact of Rohit on your career so far?

Off the ground, Rohit *bhai* treats us like his younger brothers, but on the field, he is pretty strict, and those videos that have gone viral indicate

« It's a great feeling to have played Test cricket for India. For me, it's the ultimate format of the game »